

CST309 : GLOBAL CITIZENSHIP

Project: Global Citizenship in Action

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Digital Rights as the New Frontier of Global Citizenship

Introduction

Digital technology is a necessary component of the modern world of globalization today. Only a few areas will have much of the contemporary human activity mediated over digital platforms, and these are communication, education, governance, and activism. Digital rights, such as access to the Internet, data protection, freedom of expression and antisurveillance have, in turn, become fundamental spheres of human dignity and democracy. The rights, in themselves, are not equal though. Though billions of people are enjoying the fruits of digital inclusion, about 2.7 billion of the population is not connected and the largest proportion of the unconnected population is spread all around the peripheral territories in the Global South (International Telecommunication Union [ITU], 2022).

Our team decided to work on this topic due to the perspective of the promising and contradictory nature of global citizenship. On the one hand, innovations based on IT help individuals engage in global debates and create campaigns to defend social justice, as well as access the necessary information. On the other, they reinforce inequalities, encourage surveillance and institutionalize power imbalances across the world. The study of digital rights within the context of being a global citizen allows us to explore the ways in which solidarity may assist in making the digital world a more democratic space.

Context and Stakeholders

In the digital rights issue, there is a complex and extensive web of actors at both national, transnational, and local levels.

The Multilateral Organisations and other organising bodies, including the United Nations (UN), UNESCO and the International Telecommunication Union (ITU) consider internet access a human right and advocate digital inclusion. They have their own policies through which the global connective links or internationally regulated structures of the internet are formed.

Government and states: the nation-states can control the accessibility of the web, data security, and freedom on the web. In some governments, open digital engagement and participation is embraced,

some deter participation and open engagement, and some practice censorship, controlled access, or spy on their citizens. The provided strain is emblematic of the model of the postnational digital citizen.

Corporations and Technology Providers Multinational Companies (Google, Meta, and Microsoft, etc.) are the infrastructure and platform providers that facilitate international communication. On one hand, they give the information presented to the user, on the other hand, they use the user as well, which in a very negative way can be translated into privacy and responsibility.

Civil Society and Non governmental Organization: Digital Rights, hand on, apt and resistive against candling in digital rights, hand on censorship and apt and resistive practices against censorship are supported and practiced by such agencies as Digital non governmental Organization that influences and involves all the forms of corporations.

People and Society: the digital ecosystem benefits and harms citizens, migrants, activists, marginalized people, etc. To refugees it is life itself and to youth activists it is mobilization worldwide.

Such an interaction is seen to disclose the reality that the individual actor does not feel safe of digital rights- effort would then be too cross-border and that is what would be appreciated by global citizenship.

Project Description

One of the most prominent campaigns against digital rights can be seen in the campaign, Keep It On, launched in 2016 by Access Now in opposition to government-imposed internet shutdowns across the globe. Internet shutdowns are scheduled disruptions to internet communication that are typically associated with an election, protest, or a crisis. Such shutdowns limit freedom of speech, access to information and civil liberties, and democracy and human rights are undermined.

Actions Taken:

Keep It On movement unites over 280 organizations in 105 countries. It documents cases of closures, educates through publication of reports and puts governments on their toes to implement digital

freedoms. The campaign also collaborates with UN agencies, regional activists and local activists to publicize the shutdowns as violating international law.

Methods Used:

1. Documentation and Research: Access Now gathers the information about the shutdowns and publishes annual reports that name the governments and corporations behind those acts.

2. Advocacy and Policy Engagement: The campaign pushes supranational organizations like the UN Human Rights Council into making statements which declare internet shutdowns a violation of human rights.

3. Capacity Building: Due to training support, the activists and the civil society groups operating at the local levels are currently in a state of shutdowns reporting and activating digital rights in their jurisdictions.

4. Strategic Litigation: The campaign would prefer courts that question shutdowns through litigation including petitions to regional human rights tribunals.

Impact:

It has also been successful in cajoling governments to reverse or limit closures in certain cases e.g. during election years in Africa and South Asia. It has also pressured the UN to vote resolutions stating that access to the internet is a right. In an environment of shutdowns, Keep It On demonstrates the power of action in the world-wide campaign against authoritarian tendencies and the need to create a more democratic online future.

Global Citizenship Analysis

The Keep It On campaign describes how digital rights can intersect basic concepts of global citizenship.

Cosmopolitanism: The campaign itself is cosmopolitan as it introduces internet access as a right that is not limited by border. It is more concerned with shared responsibility to protect international freedoms regardless of nationality or civilization.

Intercultural Communication: Due to the shutdowns, marginalized communities are disproportionately represented during the period of crisis. The intercultural awareness and intercultural solidarity being created through the campaign are in accordance with the theme of intercultural competence in the UNESCO framework because it allows activists to share their stories all over the world (UNESCO, 2013).

Post national citizenry: Just as supranational citizenry jeopardizes the territorial boundaries of the nation-state, digital rights change participation beyond the territorial state. The movement demonstrates how individuals can demand their rights on international levels and avoid repressive state systems.

Digital divide: still a paradox. The closures are typically in developing regions where access to digital technology is already limited, which contributes to expansion of the gap between the Global North and South. The campaign reveals such inequalities as it tries to advance more justifiable digital inclusions.

Some activist citizenship forms: Keep It On is the activist citizenship since it operates through transnational networks to keep states and corporations accountable. It demonstrates how the synergies between the grass-roots and international actors can be used to stand against the practice of exclusion. In this respect, the campaign transforms theory into practice: it proves the possibility to be a global citizen when you act together, however, it also reveals the paradox of structural inequalities that limit the digital freedoms of most populations.

Conclusion

So when we discuss digital rights as the frontier of global citizenship we find that technology is not a creative resource but a political landscape where belonging, participation, justice is constructed. Through the case study of the campaign by the organization Access Now, titled Keep It On, we could see how global challenges such as internet shutdowns illustrate the potential of digital empowerment, and the irony of exclusion and inequality.

As a group we learnt that global citizenship was not an ideal but a practice founded on daily struggle to gain rights and justice. The online world reminds us of the interrelations of communities and the necessity to do everything together across the border. However, we also had challenges, such as the inheritance of dictatorial regimes, corporate monopolies, and the fact that not everyone has equal access to digital technology means that not everyone can enjoy digital rights.

As mentioned in this reflection, multi-level citizenship local, national and transnational must unite in an effort that aims at safeguarding digital freedoms. Lastly, in the digital age it requires more than critical sensitivity to inequalities to be a global citizen: action to create a more positive and inclusive digital future.

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